

HealthTech

HARD

[PROBLEM P09]

Uncertain Waiting Times in Hospital Outpatient Departments

01 PROBLEM SUMMARY

Patients often receive a token or appointment time that provides little indication of when they will actually be seen.

02 CONTEXT & AFFECTED GROUPS

Busy outpatient departments serve scheduled appointments, walk- ins, referrals, follow-ups, diagnostic cases, and emergencies. Consultation times vary, clinicians may be called away, and some patients require priority based on medical need.

03 DETAILED PROBLEM SPECIFICATION

Patients often receive a token or appointment time that provides little indication of when they will actually be seen. Queue order may change because of triage, no-shows, delayed doctors, room changes, or consultations that take longer than expected. Patients who leave temporarily risk missing their turn, while those who remain must wait in crowded spaces. Older adults, people with disabilities, caregivers, parents with children, and hourly workers face particular difficulty when waiting times are unpredictable.

04 STAKES & CONSEQUENCES IF UNADDRESSED

Long and uncertain waits increase congestion, stress, infection exposure, lost wages, missed meals or medication, and conflict with hospital staff. Poor visibility also makes it harder for departments to manage patient flow and expectations.

05 KEY PROBLEM SCOPE & OBJECTIVES

- Patients often receive a token or appointment time that provides little indication of when they will actually be seen.
- Queue order may change because of triage, no-shows, delayed doctors, room changes, or consultations that take longer than expected.
- Patients who leave temporarily risk missing their turn, while those who remain must wait in crowded spaces.
- Older adults, people with disabilities, caregivers, parents with children, and hourly workers face particular difficulty when waiting times are unpredictable.